

Session 15: Jesus' Kingdom Mission

Key Takeaways

- The two-sentence summary of Matthew 4:17, "Change course! The Kingdom of the skies has come near," encapsulates the core of what Jesus preaches throughout his ministry.
- Matthew adapts quotes from the Psalms and Prophets by using key words from other texts to highlight a network of connected passages.
- The most unexpected aspects of Jesus' message about the Kingdom are not its ideals, but the people to and through whom that Kingdom will come and what it will look like when it arrives.

Matthew 4:12-17

¹² Now, when he heard that **Ioannes** had been handed over, he departed into **Galilaia**,
¹³ and having left Nazara, coming he dwelt in Kapharnaoum **beside the sea**, in the regions of **Zaboulon and Nephthalim**,

¹⁴ so that **what was spoken through Esaias the prophet would be fulfilled**, saying,

¹⁵ "Land of **Zaboulon** and land of **Nephthalim**, path of **the sea**, **beyond the Iordanes**, **Galilaia** of the nations,

a ¹⁶ the people **sitting in darkness**,

b **a great light** they have seen,

a' and to those sitting in a country and shadow of **death**,

b' **a light has east-arisen** on them."

¹⁷ From then on, Iesous began to announce and say,
"Change-direction!
Because **the kingdom of** **the skies** has come near!"

This unit picks up the theme of Jesus’ geographical movement from Matthew 3:13-4:11.

- Jesus arrives to see John at the Jordan river (Matt. 3:13-17).
- Jesus goes to the wilderness (Matt. 4:1).
- Jesus hears about John and retreats to Galilee (Matt. 4:12).
- Jesus leaves Nazareth and goes to live by the sea of Galilee (Matt. 4:13).

These movements help us see the design structure of this section, which consists of three short panels.

- A - v. 12-13: Jesus hears about John and moves from Nazareth to live by the sea
 - B - v. 14-16: How Jesus’ choice fulfills the Scriptures
- A’ - v. 17: Jesus’ message (= John’s) once he comes to live by the sea: The Kingdom of God is here!

Darkness and Light and the Sea

Matthew signals a major shift in the story with this seventh and final “fulfillment” quotation from the Scriptures. The quotation comes from Isaiah, just like the first quotation back in Matthew 1:23 (from Isa. 7:14), and so Matthew forms an inclusio frame around all seven of the quotations with the words of Isaiah, now from Isaiah 9:1-2.

Matthew adapts the wording of Isaiah 9:1-2 to fit with the main themes he wants to highlight from this moment in Jesus’ mission.

Isaiah 8:23-9:1 in Original Languages (Masoretic Hebrew Texts & Old Greek)	Isaiah 8:23-9:1 in English
כי לא מועף לאשר מוצק לה²³ כעת הראשון הקל ארצה זבלון וארצה נפתלי והאחרון הכביד דרך הים עבר הירדן גליל הגוים: העם ההלכים בחשך¹ ראו אור גדול ישבי בארץ צלמות אור נגה עליהם:	For there will be no gloom for the one who was in distress As in the time of the beginning, he humiliated the land of Zevulun and the land of Naphtali, but in the end he has honored the way of the Sea, across the Jordan, Galilee of the nations, and the people walking in the darkness, they have seen a great light, those sitting in the land of deep-darkness a light has shone upon them.
Isaiah Comparison. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).	

Isaiah 8:23-9:1 in Original Languages (Masoretic Hebrew Texts & Old Greek)

Isaiah 8:23-9:1 in English

²³ και ουκ απορηθησεται ο εν στενοχωρια ων
εως καιρου.
Τουτο πρωτον ποιει, ταχυ ποιει,
χωρα Ζαβουλων, η γη Νεφθαλιμ
οδον θαλασσης **και οι λοιποι οι την**
παραλιαν
κατοικουντες και πρραν του Ιορδανου,
Γαλιλαια των εθνων
¹ ο λαος ο **πορευομενος** εν σκοτει,
ιδετε φως μεγα,
οι **κατοικουντες** εν χωρα και σκια θανατου,
φως **λαμψει** εφ' υμας.

and he will not be perplexed, the one in distress,
for a time,
Do this first, do it quickly,
region of Zaboulon, land of Nephtholim,
the way of the sea, **and those left living by the**
coast and beyond the Jordan,
Galilee of the nations,
the people **walking** in darkness,
look, a great light,
those **dwelling** in the region and shadow of
death,
a light **will shine upon** them,

Matthew 4:15–16

¹⁵ **Γη** Ζαβουλων καὶ γη Νεφθαλιμ,
οδον θαλασσης, -----
περαν του Ιορδανου,
Γαλιλαια των εθνων,
¹⁶ ο λαος ο **καθημενος** εν σκοτει
φως **ειδεν** μεγα,
και τοις **καθημενοις** εν χωρα και σκια
θανατου
φως **ανετειλεν** αυτοις.

Land of Zaboulon and land of Nephtholim,
way of the sea, -----
beyond the Jordan,
Galilee of the nations,
the people **sitting** in darkness,
they have seen a great light,
and those **sitting** the region and shadow of
death,
a light **rises on** them,

Isaiah Comparison. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

Matthew's quotation does not precisely match either the Masoretic Hebrew text or the Old Greek Septuagint. His quotation shows some unique agreements with one against the other, which complicates the typical assumption that the New Testament authors simply read and quoted from the Greek Septuagint.

- Agreements with the Hebrew against the Greek
 - "land of Zebulun" (w/ Hebrew) instead of "region of Zaboulon" (Greek)
 - "they have seen" (w/ Hebrew) instead of "look!" (Greek)
 - "sitting in the region" (w/ Hebrew) instead of "dwelling" (Greek)
- Disagreements with both Hebrew and Greek
 - "sitting in darkness" (Matthew's Greek) vs. "walking in darkness" (Hebrew and Greek)
 - "a light rises on them" (Matthew's Greek) vs. "shines on them" (Hebrew and Greek)

Isaiah 9 Blended With Isaiah 42 and Isaiah 60

There are two places in Matthew's quotation of [Isaiah 9](#) that disagree with both the Hebrew and Greek traditions.

1. The people are described as "sitting" (καθηναι) in darkness, as opposed to "walking" (הלך or πορευω).
2. The light is described as "rising" (ανατελλω) upon the nations, instead of "shining" (הגה or λαμπω).

This is another place where Matthew has blended together the key words of multiple hyperlinked texts that are thematically related and hyperlinked within the composition of Isaiah, namely 42:6-7 and 60:1-2.

Isaiah 42:1-9 LEB

¹ Look! **Here is my servant**; I hold him,
my chosen one, in whom my soul delights.

I have put my spirit on him;

he will bring justice forth to the nations. ...

⁶ ... and I have given you as a covenant of the people, **as a light** of the nations,

⁷ to open the blind eyes,

to bring the prisoner out from the dungeon,

those sitting (ישב / καθηναι) **in darkness** from the house of imprisonment.

⁸ I am Yahweh, that is my name,

and I do not give my glory to another, nor my praise to the idols.

⁹ Look! the former things have come,
and I declare new things.

I announce them to you **before they rise up** (ανατελλω).

Isaiah 60:1-3 LEB

¹ Arise, shine! For **your light** has come,
and the glory of Yahweh **has risen** (זרר / ανατελλω) on you.

² For look! **Darkness** shall cover the earth,
and thick **darkness the peoples**,
but Yahweh will shine on you,
and his glory will appear over you.

³ And nations shall come to your light,
and kings to the bright light of your sunrise.

In both passages, a divine light shines on the nations through God's servant ([Isa. 42](#)) or upon the new Jerusalem ([Isa. 60](#)), and the nations come (linked to [Isa. 2:1-5](#)) and find God's justice and instruction that leads to life and freedom, not just from imperial oppression, but from death itself.

Messianic Hope: Isaiah 9 in the Context of Isaiah

Isaiah 8:23-9:1 is one small snippet of a cycling set of themes within [Isaiah 1-12](#), specifically within [Isaiah 6:1-9:6](#).

	Israel's Rebellion	Time of Divine Judgment	Time of Divine Salvation
Isaiah 6	Israel's "hard" heart/blind/deaf	Exile and devastation of Judah	Holy seed remains
Isaiah 7	Ahaz' rejection of Isaiah's "sign"	Assyrian devastation of Judah	Immanuel and remnant
Isaiah 8-9	Isa. 8:11 "the way of this people"	Stumbling, shattering, darkness	• Light, defeated oppressor • Messianic king!
Isaiah 8:16-9:1	• Isaiah's prophetic message rejected • Isa. 8:16-18 Sealed scroll passed on to disciples	• Period of "waiting" • Isa. 9:1a "the former time"	• Fulfillment of divine promise! • Isa. 9:1b "the latter time"

Isaiah 9's Context in Isaiah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

Within this section, a series of poetic sequences culminate with the anticipation of a future “seed” who will signal the restoration of Israel and the time of divine salvation. The reader is meant to meditate on the relationship between the poetic images: holy seed ([Isa. 6:12-13](#)), the Immanuel child ([Isa. 7:14](#)), the arrival of God’s creative light, and the birth of a divine-child-savior ([Isa. 9:5-6](#)).

Within the larger frame of the book of Isaiah, all of these promises of divine salvation culminate in the deliverance of Jerusalem in the days of Hezekiah ([Isa. 36-39](#)). The story of the city’s deliverance is the pivot of the entire scroll, making up the central literary movement.

Chapters	Content	Literary Type
Isa. 1-12	Jerusalem rebels, is judged, but a remnant is redeemed	Poetry + Narrative [Ahaz]
Isa. 13-27	God topples the nations while preserving a remnant	Poetry
Isa. 28-35	Jerusalem to be destroyed, but a remnant delivered	Poetry

Isaiah Literary Movements. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

Chapters	Content	Literary Type
Isa. 36-39	Jerusalem saved from Assyria > Babylonian exile predicted	Narrative + Poetry [Hezekiah]
Isa. 40-48	Israel called out of Babylon as a witness to the nations	Poetry
Isa. 49-55	God calls a servant to act on behalf of rebellious Israel	Poetry
Isa. 56-66	Promise of the new Jerusalem for all nations	Poetry
<i>Isaiah Literary Movements. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).</i>		

However, after the city's great deliverance in Isaiah [36-38](#), [chapter 39](#) comes along as a great test-and-failure narrative, where King Hezekiah attempts to ally with the Babylonians and dishonors the house of God. His failure generates hope for a future figure who will become the true fulfillment of the messianic hopes of chapters 1-12 sometime after the Babylonian era. Matthew, who perceives the future-pointing momentum of Isaiah's promises, applies these hopes to Jesus.

Another key metaphor in Isaiah is that of God's wisdom and salvation depicted as a period of darkness and shining light.

The image of darkness as a symbol of divine judgment begins in [Isaiah 5:30](#) and [Isaiah 8:22](#), and the image of light is introduced in [Isaiah 2:1-5](#) and then developed in [Isaiah 8:23-9:2](#). These twin symbols develop side by side throughout the book (see [Isa. 30:26](#); [42:6-7](#), [16](#); [45:7](#); [49:9](#); [51:4](#); [58:10](#); [59:9](#)) and culminate in the great triad of new Jerusalem poems in [Isaiah 60-62](#) (see [Isa. 60:1-2](#), [19-20](#)).

What's the Point of the Fulfillment Quotation?

Matthew's goal is to show how Jesus' arrival onto the scene in Galilee is the reality anticipated by Israel's covenant story. Specifically, he is the divine-human messianic deliverer from the line of David, and he is also the divine, heavenly light shining on those in darkness.

Notice that the theme of "light" and "shining" has been a major theme in all of Matthew 1-4.

- The angels "appeared shining" ([φαινω](#) in [Matt. 1:20](#); [2:13](#), [19](#)).
- The magi come from the "sunrise-east" ([ανατολη](#) in [Matt. 2:1](#)).
- The magi saw a "star in the sunrise-east" ([αστηρ ανατολη](#) in [Matt. 2:2](#), [9-10](#)).
- The magi's star "appeared shining" ([φαινω](#) in [Matt. 2:7](#)).
- Jesus' arrival by the sea is a "great light" that "sun-rises" ([ανατελλω](#)) on Gailiee ([Matt. 4:16](#)).

Matthew also focuses on the theme of Jesus' Davidic heritage and ancestry throughout all of Matthew 1-4 as well (the genealogy, Joseph as son of David, the Immanuel promise, the [Micah 5](#) quotation).

In portraying Jesus as the divine-human Davidic king who brings God's light into the world, Matthew continues a core theme that already existed within Isaiah. Not only that, Matthew shapes the introduction to his Gospel account in ways that apply these specific images to Jesus. It is this type of dialogue between the apostles and prophets that we see all over the New Testament. The Hebrew Scriptures are not simply a reservoir of symbols and predictions that the apostles apply to Jesus, they have also meditated on the meaning of Jesus in light of the Hebrew Scriptures and written their accounts to show the deep continuity that exists between the two.

Jesus and the Kingdom of God

Matthew 4:17 Instructor's Translation

From then on, Jesus began
to announce and say,
"Change-direction!
Because **the kingdom of** **the skies** has come near!"

With these words we come to a major pivot in the storyline of Matthew's Gospel, and the large section of 3:1-4:17 draws to a close. Jesus' arrival onto the scene was prefaced by John the Immerser's mission ([Matt. 3:1-12](#)), and Jesus' baptism signals the passing of the baton, so to speak, from John to Jesus. Jesus then entered into the wilderness where his identity (as the Son of God) and vocation (to bring God's heavenly Kingdom) were tested, and he passed the test successfully. After doing so, Jesus relocated to the sea of Galilee and began his mission to announce that God's reign was arriving on Earth in and through himself.

This is a pivotal and programmatic line, signaling an important transition in the story, as Jesus passes from his "preparation" period into the first stage of his mission as Son of God.

Long ago, Jack Kingsbury noticed that this key line is matched at one other macro-structural hinge moment in Matthew's story (see his [Matthew: Structure, Christology, Kingdom](#), chapter 1).

Matthew 4:17 Instructor's Translation

From then on, Jesus began (*απο τότε ηρξατο ο Ιησους*)
to announce and say
"Change-direction!
Because the kingdom of the skies has come near!"

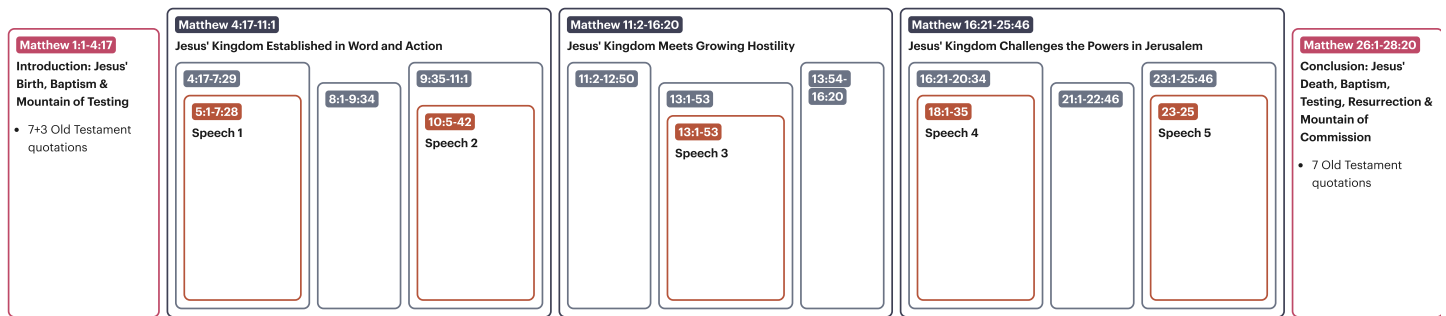
Matthew 16:21 Instructor's Translation

From then on, Jesus began (*απο τότε ηρξατο ο Ιησους*)
to point out that it was necessary for him to go to Jerusalem,
and to suffer many things by the elders and chief-priests and scribes,
and to be killed,
and on the third day, to be raised up,

It is important to note that in the macro-structure of Matthew, these two scenes come at precisely matching moments in Jesus' messianic journey.

1. His transition from a period of preparation in Nazareth and the wilderness into a period of announcing the Kingdom of God in the region of Galilee (Matt. 4:12-16:20)
2. His transition from announcing God's Kingdom in Galilee to the long journey to Jerusalem where he will challenge the powers in the city and temple (Matt. 16:21-28:20)

It is no coincidence that these two moments are matching macro-structural hinges that simultaneously conclude and introduce the next section of Matthew's account. These matching transitions appear at the beginning of the first and last major parts of the central core that makes up Matthew 4:12-25:46, making Galilee and Jerusalem the central focus points of the story.



Matthew 1-28. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

Reflection Question

How would you unpack the two-sentence summary of Jesus' message, "Repent, for the Kingdom of Heaven has come near"?